My chance came in the fifth over. Sehwag had just been dismissed at the other end, lbw to left-arm seamer Nathan Bracken for 11, and Lee was steaming in. His second ball was slightly wide but I still decided to go for a drive through cover. I connected moderately well and the ball raced to the fence. Lee just gave me another smile and walked back to his mark. I thought I knew what he would try next. He ran in fast and, as anticipated, bowled a fuller-length ball. I came down hard at it and hit it straight back at him. It must have been one of the most powerful shots I have hit in my life. Lee didn't have a hope of bending down to stop the ball. In fact, the ball had reached the boundary by the time he finished his follow-through.

By now Lee was even more pumped up and the next ball was a 151 kph delivery, which I defended off the back foot. I was determined to keep attacking and I got another opportunity off the fifth ball of the over. It was full and fast and again I hit it back past Lee for four. While the first straight drive had gone to the left of the bowler, this one went to his right. Those two drives gave me a lot of confidence and I went on to make 44. When I got out in the twenty-sixth over we needed 64 runs and Rohit Sharma and Dhoni played well to finish off the job.

Immediately after the match, I started to feel some soreness in my adductors, the muscles in the groin, and informed John Gloster about the problem. We took remedial steps but the pain refused to go away and I was still feeling it when we played our last pool match against Sri Lanka on 26 February in Hobart. It was a game we had to win to qualify for the three-match final against Australia. Sri Lanka scored 179, with Ishant Sharma and Praveen Kumar both taking four wickets, and when our innings started I managed to connect well from the off and went on to make 63 as we knocked off the runs in thirty-three overs. It felt good to spend time out in the middle again after several low scores and I headed to Sydney for the first final relieved at having scored some runs.

While I was looking forward to the finals, I was conscious that the pain in my adductors was getting worse after every practice session. I was having problems with running, twisting and even bending down to pick up a ball. It reached a stage where in fielding practice I had to just stand at the stumps while my team-mates threw the ball in. With the final just a day away, painkillers were the only remedy.

## CB Series, first final, Sydney, 2 March 2008